

MANDAR DEODHAR

UDDHAV THACKERAY SEEMS to be a changed man since he lost his seat as Maharashtra chief minister on June 30. In the next 10 days, he visited Shiv Sena Bhavan, the party headquarters in central Mumbai's Dadar, four times. That may sound like an innocuous factoid, but the number outstrips the count of his visits to the party HQ in the past three years. He has also been addressing party officials and elected representatives every alternate day. Uddhav's sudden proactiveness is no surpise, though. It's a measure of his keenness to hold on to whatever ground he has under his feet. Specifically, to save his party from going lock, stock and barrel into the hands of Eknath Shinde, the man who upstaged him in a coup and eventually landed the CM's post.

After Shinde succeeded in splitting the Sena in the legislative assembly, with 40 out of 55 MLAs on his side, the threat is real—and quite existential. An awareness of how desperate the situation is has brought in a tactical nuance not seen during the days of protracted conflict a fortnight ago. That's why, after the 12 Lok Sabha MPs still loyal to him urged Uddhav to break with the opposition and back BJP candidate Droupadi Murmu for president, the official Sena announced its intent to do so on July 12. The idea is to dial down the mood of unremitting hostility with the rebel camp, and perchance, some say, even reach for a détente with the BJP. With embitterment high on both sides of the Sena divide, it's difficult to predict a rapprochement with any confidence. But the exigencies driving events are quite dire: there are vital local body elections at stake. And even a conditional return to the right by the Uddhav camp could rewrite Maharashtra's political equations once again.

Legally, the Shinde group may still lack a formal stamp but, comfortably ensconced in power, it has several advantages. Even within the Sena, the ground is tilted in the new CM's favour. The lingering disquiet—if not dissent—within the parent was evident when seven out of 19 Lok Sabha MPs bunked a meeting Uddhav had called at his residence on July 11. (That's when the attendees persuaded him to pick tact over obstinacy.) Shinde has also managed to get the backing of almost all the councillors from the municipal corporations of Thane, Navi Mumbai and Kalyan-Dombivali. When former MP Anandrao Adsul quit all party posts on July 6, expressing anguish against Thackeray and his coterie, it only heightened the sense of an ongoing soil erosion—that Adsul had the Enforcement Directorate knocking on his doors last October will remain a forgotten footnote. Uddhav's only hope of stanching further blood-loss at present is a petition before the Supreme Court seeking disqualification of Shinde and 15 others for not following the party's orders. On July 11, the SC said it will form a constitution bench to hear the petition as an immediate hearing was not possible. So the disqualification question could stay in suspended animation for a couple of months, closing the doors on any scope for immediate relief for Uddhav.

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This is proving to be a defining crisis in Uddhav's unusual political career. Does he have what it takes to survive and endure? He does possess an essential ingredient—in contrast to his image as a reluctant politician, Uddhav has always been an ambitious one. In his initial days in the early '90s, he spent more time on wildlife photography and gave right of way to his more charismatic cousin, Raj. However, after his father and Sena founder Bal Thackeray entrusted him with the responsibility to draw up battle plans for the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) election in 1997, he gave evidence of the shrewd politician lurking within. Uddhav snatched victory from the Congress in his first-ever outing, and is yet to lose his grip over the BMC. After Balasaheb elevated him as Sena working president in 2003, against the wishes of Raj, Uddhav succeeded in finishing off all his political opponents—till the revolt by Shinde upended his world.

There's still one significant silver lining for Uddhav: the party and cadre's trust in him. Barring a few exceptions, no Sena office-bearer has supported Shinde. Almost the entire Shiv Sena national executive—249 out of 256 members—has expressed solidarity with him too. That has given Balasaheb's son a sense that he can hold on to his patrimony and avert a split in the